RUNNING EFFECTIVE MEETINGS

Facilitator's Guide

DESCRIPTION	Utilize this facilitator's guide for: • Running Effective Meetings Video • Creating a Best Practice Agenda Resource Sheet • Two Critical Roles for Running an Effective Meeting Resource Sheet
OBJECTIVES	Participants should be able to: • Identify both the best practices and challenges of running an effective meeting. • Analyze the role a leader plays prior to, during, and after a meeting. • Understand how the best practices of creating an agenda can positively impact both the flow and participants perception of the meeting. • Utilize the two roles of effective meetings to better understand how they lead to meeting success.
Time for Facilitation	Between 20 - 120 minutes

Introduction

Brief Starting Intro:

Meetings are a central aspect of leadership, and poorly run meetings can result in wasted time, unclear outcomes, and decreased engagement. Leaders who receive proper training on meeting facilitation can create structured, goal-oriented discussions that foster collaboration, drive decision-making, and maintain focus. Training equips leaders with the skills to manage diverse perspectives, encourage participation, and keep the meeting aligned with its objectives. Without these skills, meetings can easily become unproductive, leading to frustration and a lack of progress on key initiatives.

Learning to create a best practice agenda is equally important, as it serves as the blueprint for a successful meeting. A well-crafted agenda not only ensures that key topics are covered

but also provides a clear pathway for the meeting, outlining discussion points, time allocations, and the desired outcomes. It helps participants come prepared, know what to expect, and remain focused on the objectives at hand. An effective agenda also includes elements like role assignments and preparatory materials, which can drastically enhance the meeting's flow. Additionally, the roles of a **time guardian** and a **note keeper** are critical for maintaining structure and accountability. The time guardian ensures that discussions stay on track and prevents meetings from running over time, while the note keeper records key points, decisions, and action items, ensuring nothing is forgotten and participants can refer to the outcomes afterward. Together, these roles help create a more efficient, goal-driven meeting environment where everyone stays focused and results are clearly documented.

Pre-Facilitation: Check with participants to see if they watched the video and read the resource articles. They should have both watched and read the resources prior to asking the following questions.

Best Practice Facilitation: Place participants into pairs of two so that they can share first with the other participant before sharing their answer with the whole group. This “pair and share” technique allows individuals to test out their answer(s) with someone else first (instilling confidence in the answer) and helps to start building stronger relationships with others in the program.

Depending on the time you have, select the questions that work within your schedule for training. Since we are utilizing the “pair and share” method, you should provide the participants with 2 minutes each to discuss their answers (let them know when to switch to keep them on time). Then have those who want to share their answers with the whole group a chance to do so (select 2 or 3 people to share - do not force participation). This can take up to 5 minutes. In total the pair and share technique for each question will take approximately 10 minutes. If you do not use the pair and share, allow 5-7 minutes for individuals to respond to the who group.

Running an Effective Meeting General Questions

The following questions are based on the Running an Effective Meeting video:

1. Think about the last meeting you attended—did you leave feeling inspired and ready to take action, or was it just another hour of your life you’ll never get back? What factors contributed to making the meeting either productive or unproductive, and how could the meeting have been improved to ensure a more engaging and actionable outcome?
2. Have you ever scheduled or attended a meeting that could have been handled more efficiently through an email or memo? What criteria do you now use to decide whether a meeting is necessary or not, and how can you communicate this more effectively to your team to avoid unnecessary meetings in the future?

3. Can you recall a time when too many or too few participants were invited to a meeting? How did that affect the quality of the discussion or decision-making, and what process do you follow when deciding who should attend a meeting to ensure the right people are invited? How can you keep meetings small while still ensuring that critical insights and expertise are present?
4. How do you manage time during meetings to make sure discussions stay on track and within the allotted time? Can you describe a time when a meeting ran over due to poor time management, what could have been done differently, and how do you ensure that all topics are covered without rushing through key discussions?
5. What strategies do you use to encourage participation from quieter team members during meetings? Can you share a time when getting everyone to contribute led to a breakthrough or a better decision, and how do you handle dominant voices in a meeting to ensure balanced participation from the entire group?
6. After a meeting, how do you typically follow up on action items and decisions made? How do you ensure accountability and follow-through once action items have been assigned, and what methods can you use to improve your follow-up process to ensure that participants are clear on their responsibilities and deadlines?

Additional Activity on *Effective Meetings*:

1. Self-Assessment: Begin the workshop by providing participants with the Running Effective Meetings Self-Assessment questionnaire (*provided at the end of this facilitation guide*). Encourage them to reflect on their current level of skill running meetings. Ask participants to rate their effectiveness in key areas such as creating an agenda, understanding the objective, inviting the right people, keeping the meeting on time, and delivering on results.
2. Group Discussion: Facilitate a group discussion where participants share their self-assessment results and insights. Encourage open dialogue about common challenges and best practices for running an effective meeting. Guide participants to identify common themes and patterns in addressing these unique dynamics of running an effective meeting.

Creating a Best Practice Agenda Questions

The following questions are based on Creating a Best Practice Agenda Article:

1. How often do you clearly define the purpose of a meeting before creating an agenda, and how does this impact the meeting's effectiveness? How do you align your meeting agenda with the meeting's overall goals? Have you ever experienced a meeting where the agenda didn't match the intended purpose, and what was the result? What adjustments can you make to better align your agendas with the outcomes you want to achieve?
2. In your experience, how does using a structured agenda help keep meetings focused and productive? Can you recall a meeting that went off track because of a lack of structure, and what could have been done differently? What techniques do you use to ensure that your meetings stay on track and follow the agenda?

3. How do you prioritize high-impact topics in your meeting agenda, and why is this important? Have you ever noticed a difference in meeting outcomes when critical issues are addressed first versus later in the meeting? What can you do to improve how you prioritize and allocate time for the most important discussions?
4. How do you assign ownership for different agenda items, and what role does this play in ensuring accountability? Can you share an example of when clearly assigning roles, like presenter or facilitator, led to more productive discussions? What changes could you make to ensure that all agenda items have clear owners in future meetings?
5. How do you ensure that action items are clearly summarized and assigned at the end of a meeting? How do you typically follow up on action items and decisions after a meeting? What improvements could you make to your current process to ensure better accountability and follow-through?

Additional *Meeting Agenda* Activity:

Objective: This activity engages participants in the process of creating a best practice meeting agenda. Participants will also critique and refine their agendas using feedback from their peers, focusing on structuring meetings to be purposeful, efficient, and results-driven.

1. **Introduction:** The facilitator introduces the topic of creating a best practice agenda, emphasizing how proper agenda structure can lead to more productive and efficient meetings. The importance of aligning meeting agendas with the goals of the session is highlighted. Facilitators explain how poor agendas lead to disorganized discussions, frustration, and wasted time.
2. **Group Discussion:** Participants are asked to reflect on their recent experiences with meetings—both good and bad. The facilitator guides the discussion with questions such as:
   - What makes a meeting effective or ineffective?
   - How does a well-structured agenda impact the flow and productivity of a meeting?
   - Have you ever been in a meeting that was successful because of a clear agenda?
3. **Creating a Meeting Agenda:** Participants are divided into small groups of 3-4. Each group is tasked with creating an agenda for a hypothetical meeting. The facilitator provides different meeting scenarios (provided at the end of this facilitation guide), such as a strategy planning session, budget review, or project update. The agenda must include:
   - A clear meeting purpose and objectives
   - Time allocation for each topic
   - A structured flow of discussion (starting with high-impact topics)
   - Assigned roles for note-taking, timekeeping, and facilitation
   - SMART goals for specific outcomes (e.g., “By the end of the meeting, identify 3 strategies for improving customer service”)
4. **Present and Critique:** Each group presents their agenda to the rest of the participants. As each group presents, others are encouraged to ask questions and provide constructive feedback:
   - Is the meeting purpose clear?
   - Are the time allocations realistic?
   - Does the agenda structure reflect the urgency and importance of topics?
   - Are the goals actionable, specific, and aligned with the purpose?

5. **Refining the Agenda:** After receiving feedback, each group takes 10 minutes to revise their agenda. The facilitator encourages them to adjust their time blocks, clarify objectives, and ensure the meeting has a logical flow with SMART goals.
6. **Final Presentation and Reflection:** Groups present their final, refined agendas. The facilitator highlights key takeaways from the activity:
   - How a well-designed agenda can lead to more purposeful meetings
   - The importance of aligning the agenda with the meeting's objectives
   - How clear time allocations and structure can prevent meetings from going off-track
7. **Debrief and Action Plan:** To conclude, participants individually reflect on how they can apply these best practices to their real-life meetings. They write down one to two action steps for improving their own meeting agendas. The facilitator encourages ongoing review and refinement of agendas, using the SMART framework to ensure actionable outcomes.
8. **Debrief and Wrap-Up:**
   The facilitator wraps up the session by discussing how a clear, structured agenda benefits not only meeting productivity but also team engagement and morale. Leaders are encouraged to revisit and continuously improve their agenda-creation skills to maximize meeting effectiveness. This activity allows participants to engage in both the creation and critique process, learning firsthand how to structure a best practice agenda that keeps meetings on track and aligned with clear goals.

Two Critical Roles for Running an Effective Meeting Questions

The following questions are based on the 2 Critical Roles for Running an Effective Meeting Article:

1. How do you currently ensure that your meetings stay on track and within the allotted time? Can you think of a time when a meeting went off track, and how did it affect the overall outcome? What steps could you take to prevent similar situations in the future?
2. What role does the Time Guardian play in keeping meetings focused and efficient, and how can this role improve the productivity of your team's meetings? Have you ever been in a meeting where having a Time Guardian could have helped, and what would they have done to maintain focus? How do you think rotating the Time Guardian role among team members could benefit your team's communication and time management skills?
3. In what ways can a Time Guardian respectfully intervene when a conversation goes off-topic, and how does this help maintain meeting flow? How would you feel if someone interjected during a meeting to keep the discussion on track? What language or strategies can be used to ensure that the intervention feels supportive rather than disruptive?
4. How can the role of a Note Keeper contribute to the success of a meeting, and what key information should be captured to ensure clarity and accountability? Can you share an example of when well-documented meeting notes led to better follow-through on action items? What could have been done differently in a meeting where notes were incomplete or unclear?
5. How can having both a Time Guardian and a Note Keeper in a meeting improve accountability and efficiency? What challenges could arise if one of these roles is missing

or not effectively fulfilled? How would you encourage your team to embrace these roles and take them seriously?

Additional *2 Critical Roles* Activity:

Objective: This activity engages participants in the roles of Time Guardian and Note Keeper, allowing them to experience firsthand how these roles contribute to productive and efficient meetings. Through role-playing, participants will learn to manage meeting time effectively and ensure accurate capture of key decisions and action items.

1. **Introduction and Overview:** The facilitator introduces the topic of the Time Guardian and Note Keeper roles, emphasizing how these two roles ensure the efficiency and productivity of meetings. The facilitator briefly covers the key responsibilities of each role:
   - Time Guardian: Keeps the meeting on track, ensures discussions stay within the allocated time, and gently intervenes when the meeting goes off-course.
   - Note Keeper: Captures key points, decisions, action items, and ensures that discussions are documented for future reference.
2. **Assigning Roles and Reviewing the Agenda:** The facilitator divides participants into groups of 4-5, assigning the roles of Time Guardian, Note Keeper, Facilitator, and Participants. Each group is given a meeting agenda and scenario (*find both the scenario and agenda at the end of the facilitation guide*) to role-play. The Time Guardian will focus on keeping discussions within their allotted time, while the Note Keeper will capture key points and decisions. The agenda should include realistic time blocks for each discussion topic.
3. **Role Play: Conducting the Meeting:** The groups begin their role-play, following the agenda provided. The Time Guardian uses a timer to ensure that each discussion stays within its time limit and politely intervenes if conversations veer off track or run over time. The Note Keeper takes detailed notes on key decisions, action items, and any important points raised during the discussion. The Facilitator leads the meeting, and the remaining participants contribute to the discussions as needed.
4. **Debriefing the Role Play:**
   After the role-play, each group discusses the effectiveness of their meeting:
   - How well did the Time Guardian keep the meeting on track?
   - Were there any challenges in managing time or keeping discussions focused?
   - How effective was the Note Keeper in capturing key decisions and action items?

Each group shares their experiences with the larger group, highlighting what worked well and what could be improved.

- **Role Rotation and Second Round:** To ensure all participants experience both roles, the groups rotate roles (e.g., Time Guardian becomes Note Keeper, Note Keeper becomes Facilitator) and run through the same or a different scenario. This allows participants to practice new skills in different roles, reinforcing the importance of each role in maintaining a productive meeting.
- **Final Debrief and Reflection:** After the second round of role-play, the facilitator leads a final group discussion:

    - How did rotating roles help you better understand the importance of the Time Guardian and Note Keeper?
    - How did each role contribute to the overall success and flow of the meeting?
    - What strategies can you take back to your team to implement these roles effectively?
- **Action Planning:** Participants individually reflect on how they can incorporate these roles into their own meetings. They write down one or two actionable steps they will take to assign Time Guardian and Note Keeper roles in future meetings. The facilitator encourages participants to commit to using these roles to improve meeting efficiency and outcomes.
- **Wrap-Up:** The facilitator wraps up by summarizing the key takeaways from the activity:
    - Effective time management and organized note-taking are essential for productive meetings.
    - The Time Guardian helps keep the meeting focused and on track, ensuring efficient use of time.
    - The Note Keeper provides a reliable record of key decisions and actions, promoting accountability and follow-through.

Participants leave with practical strategies for improving meeting effectiveness through the use of these two critical roles.

General Running Effective Meetings Self Assessment

Instructions: Please rate each statement on a scale of 1 to 5, where 1 indicates "Strongly Disagree" and 5 indicates "Strongly Agree."

1. I clearly define the objective of every meeting before scheduling it.

1 2 3 4 5

2. I ensure that meetings I organize are necessary and not something that could be handled via email or memo.

1 2 3 4 5

3. I prepare and distribute an agenda before each meeting to ensure participants are prepared.

1 2 3 4 5

4. I prioritize agenda items by importance and allocate appropriate time for each.

1 2 3 4 5

5. I invite only the necessary participants to my meetings to maintain focus and efficiency.

1 2 3 4 5

6. I ensure that meetings start on time and set a professional tone from the beginning.

1 2 3 4 5

7. I use a timekeeper to help keep the meeting on track and within the allocated timeframe.

1 2 3 4 5

8. I am proactive in steering discussions back on track when conversations go off-topic.

1 2 3 4 5

9. I encourage participation from all attendees, including those who are quieter or less likely to speak up.

1 2 3 4 5

10. I use tools like round-robin discussions or breakout groups to facilitate participation.

1 2 3 4 5

11. I avoid allowing participants to use devices during the meeting to minimize distractions and foster focus.

1 2 3 4 5

12. I use technology effectively, particularly in remote or hybrid meetings, to enhance engagement and collaboration.

1 2 3 4 5

13. I ensure all participants are comfortable with the technology used in meetings and test the tools beforehand.

1 2 3 4 5

14. I summarize key decisions, outcomes, and next steps at the end of every meeting.

1 2 3 4 5

15. I assign action items to specific individuals with clear deadlines to ensure accountability.

1 2 3 4 5

16. I follow up after meetings with a written summary, reinforcing the meeting outcomes and assigned tasks.

1 2 3 4 5

17. I make sure to include important clarifications or unresolved issues in the post-meeting follow-up.

1 2 3 4 5

18. I continuously evaluate and seek to improve the structure and outcomes of the meetings I lead.

1 2 3 4 5

19. I adjust the length of my meetings based on the agenda to keep them as short and focused as possible.

1 2 3 4 5

20. I maintain a collaborative environment where all participants feel they can contribute effectively.

1 2 3 4 5

Scoring: Calculate your total score by adding up the ratings for each statement. A higher score indicates more effectiveness in the skills and habits of running an effective meeting.

Total Score: _____

Interpretation:

- **80-100**: **Meeting Master**
  You excel at running effective meetings that are focused, productive, and engaging. Your ability to manage time, foster participation, and ensure follow-up contributes to excellent results. Keep refining your practices to maintain and build on this strength.
- **60-79**: **You Are Good, With Opportunities for More Effective Meetings**
  You are doing well with your meeting management skills but may have a few areas to improve, such as enhancing participation or streamlining your agenda. Identify specific practices that could make your meetings even more productive.
- **40-59**: **Improvement Needed to Run More Effective Meetings**
  You may find that your meetings are not always as efficient or focused as they could be. Consider working on time management, clearly defining objectives, and encouraging more balanced participation. Making adjustments to your process can yield significant improvements.
- **20-39**: **Significant Development Needed to Run More Effective Meetings**
  Your meetings may often feel unproductive or inefficient. There are likely several areas to improve, such as preparing better agendas, limiting the number of attendees, and setting clearer objectives. By focusing on these key areas, you can turn your meetings into more powerful tools for collaboration and decision-making.

10 Different Meeting Scenarios

1. **Strategy Planning Session:**
   Objective: Develop a strategic plan for the next fiscal year, focusing on key business growth areas.
   SMART Goal: Identify 5 strategic initiatives to drive revenue growth by the end of the session.
2. **Budget Review Meeting:**
   Objective: Review the current quarter's financial performance and adjust the budget for the next quarter.
   SMART Goal: Agree on 3 budget reallocations to better align with departmental priorities.
3. **Project Kickoff Meeting:**
   Objective: Launch a new project by discussing goals, assigning roles, and setting timelines.
   SMART Goal: Finalize the project timeline and assign deliverables to key team members.
4. **Product Development Brainstorming Session:**
   Objective: Generate new product ideas that align with market trends.
   SMART Goal: Produce 3 viable product ideas to explore for future development.
5. **Team Feedback Session:**
   Objective: Gather feedback from the team on recent project outcomes and areas for improvement.
   SMART Goal: Identify 2 key areas for improvement and propose 3 actionable solutions.
6. **Client Update Meeting:**
   Objective: Provide the client with progress updates on an ongoing project and discuss next steps.
   SMART Goal: Review project progress and agree on 3 key milestones for the next phase.
7. **Crisis Management Meeting:**
   Objective: Address a significant issue impacting the business and develop a plan of action.
   SMART Goal: Develop a crisis response plan with 3 immediate action items to mitigate risks.
8. **Staff Performance Review Meeting:**
   Objective: Evaluate team performance over the last quarter and set goals for improvement.

SMART Goal: Set 3 measurable performance goals for each team member for the upcoming quarter.

9. **Marketing Campaign Review:**
   Objective: Review the results of the recent marketing campaign and plan improvements for future efforts.
   SMART Goal: Identify 2 successful elements and 2 areas for improvement in the next campaign.
10. **Sales Pipeline Review Meeting:**
    Objective: Assess the current sales pipeline and discuss strategies for improving lead conversion.
    SMART Goal: Develop 3 strategies to increase lead conversion by 10% over the next quarter.

Two Roles for a Meeting - Experiential Activity

Scenario:
The team is meeting to review the progress of an ongoing project, identify any roadblocks, and align on the next steps for the upcoming milestone.

Meeting Agenda:

Agenda Item	Time Allocation	Details
Welcome and Objective Overview	5 minutes	Review the purpose of the meeting and desired outcomes.
Progress Report from Each Team	15 minutes	Each team member provides a brief update (3 minutes each).
Identifying Roadblocks and Solutions	15 minutes	Discuss challenges and brainstorm solutions.
Next Steps and Timeline Review	10 minutes	Align on key upcoming tasks and deadlines.
Q&A and Discussion	5 minutes	Open floor for questions or clarification.
Summary of Decisions and Action Items	5 minutes	The Note Keeper summarizes decisions and tasks assigned.

Total Time: 55 minutes

2. Budget Review Meeting

Scenario:
The finance team is meeting with department heads to review the quarterly budget, identify areas of overspending, and determine adjustments for the next quarter.

Meeting Agenda:

Agenda Item	Time Allocation	Details
Welcome and Objective Setting	5 minutes	Outline the goal of the budget review meeting.
Review of Last Quarter's Budget	10 minutes	Finance team presents a summary of spending and variances.
Discussion on Overspending	15 minutes	Identify areas where departments exceeded budget allocations.
Budget Adjustments for Next Quarter	15 minutes	Propose adjustments for next quarter based on current needs.
Approval of Adjustments	5 minutes	Reach consensus on the changes.
Action Items and Assignments	5 minutes	Assign tasks for implementing budget adjustments.

Total Time: 55 minutes

3. Strategic Planning Session

Scenario:
The leadership team is gathering to outline the strategic goals for the next fiscal year, focusing on growth opportunities and key initiatives.

Meeting Agenda:

Agenda Item	Time Allocation	Details
Welcome and Objective Setting	5 minutes	Clarify the purpose and expected outcomes of the session.
Review of Current Strategic Goals	10 minutes	Discuss progress on current goals and their relevance.
Brainstorming New Growth Opportunities	20 minutes	Generate ideas for new strategic initiatives.
Prioritizing Strategic Initiatives	10 minutes	Evaluate and rank the ideas based on feasibility and impact.
Next Steps for Execution	5 minutes	Assign owners to initiatives and outline a timeline.
Recap and Action Items	5 minutes	Review key decisions and next steps.

Total Time: 55 minutes

4. Crisis Management Meeting

Scenario:
The team is facing an urgent issue that requires immediate resolution (e.g., a technical outage, PR issue, or supply chain disruption). The objective of the meeting is to align on a response strategy and delegate tasks to manage the crisis.

Meeting Agenda:

Agenda Item	Time Allocation	Details
Welcome and Situation Overview	5 minutes	Outline the crisis and the purpose of the meeting.
Root Cause Analysis	10 minutes	Review what caused the crisis and its potential impact.
Response Strategy Development	15 minutes	Discuss immediate actions needed to mitigate the issue.
Assigning Responsibilities	10 minutes	Delegate tasks to team members based on the action plan.
Communication Plan (Internal & External)	10 minutes	Agree on how to communicate with stakeholders and the public.
Summary of Decisions and Next Steps	5 minutes	Recap the action items and next steps for managing the crisis.

Total Time: 55 minutes

5. Team Feedback and Improvement Meeting

Scenario:
The team is meeting to reflect on recent project outcomes and identify areas for improvement in team processes and performance.

Meeting Agenda:

Agenda Item	Time Allocation	Details
Welcome and Objective Setting	5 minutes	Outline the purpose of the meeting (team reflection).
Review of Recent Project Outcomes	10 minutes	Team members share reflections on project results.
Identifying Areas for Improvement	15 minutes	Discuss what worked well and what can be improved.
Brainstorming Solutions	15 minutes	Generate ideas for improving team processes and communication.
Action Plan for Improvement	5 minutes	Agree on specific changes to be implemented moving forward.
Recap of Decisions and Action Items	5 minutes	The Note Keeper summarizes key takeaways and assigned tasks.

Total Time: 55 minutes